

you'd have seen them, you would have thought they were the home crowd watching the visitors win a game with a home run in the bottom of the ninth.

"Don't you think it will turn around?" asked a man in jogging clothes. For an hour or so we watched one particular blip—"F" for "Ford"—as it came across the screen again and again, the man's hopes rising and falling with each updraft and downdraft, as if he were cheering on a wounded bird. "Look," the man exclaimed several times, "F is holding, F has turned around," and then F would fall and he'd slump back dejectedly into his chair.

I returned home to see what they were saying on the Financial News Newtork. By midday, the market was down 250 points. One of the big differences between this Crash and the one that ushered in the Great Depression in 1929 was that you could watch this one happening in your own bedroom.

The financial newscasters, many of whom I'd counted as distant but important investment allies, seemed wild-eyed, unstable. As they babbled on, my wife asked what she should do. The fact that she was asking *me* was further evidence of the total panic into which investors had fallen.

I noticed that at least stock prices didn't look so bad on the TV tickertape, but then one of the announcers mentioned that the tape was running two hours behind so none of the prices were current. I lay down on the bed and watched the progression anyway. I ran once to the refrigerator to grab a beer, which I normally never drink.

An hour or so later, I got in the car and returned to Thomson McKinnon. By now the market was down 350 points, but the audience had cheered up. Gloomy at 200 down, cheery at 350 down—it was the enormity that took them beyond shock into a kind of idiot's bemusement. We all began to take pleasure in announcing how bad it was, especially to each arrival who just came through the door to sit down. "You know how bad it is? You *know* how bad it is? 350 points." Soon that arrival would be gleefully passing on the same news to yet another arrival.

I headed home again and spent the final hour watching television—not the Financial News Network but a game show—while